

A Comparative Study on Guilds (Shrenis) and Modern Family Businesses: Continuity of Traditional Trade Wisdom in Contemporary Entrepreneurship

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ABSTRACT

This study investigates the connection between ancient trade wisdom and modern entrepreneurship, focusing specifically on the practices of traditional guilds (Shrenis) and family-run businesses. In historical trade systems, ethical conduct, collective decision-making, and knowledge transfer across generations were central to sustaining economic activity and building strong community networks. Such practices not only ensured financial stability but also reinforced social cohesion and trust, highlighting lessons that remain relevant for contemporary business environments. The research further explores how the organizational structures of guilds resemble modern family enterprises. Both systems rely heavily on trust, succession planning, mentorship, and collaborative networks to thrive. By examining these parallels, the study demonstrates how age-old practices can inform effective leadership, strategic decision-making, and long-term sustainability in today's entrepreneurial landscape. Finally, this comparative analysis provides practical insights for entrepreneurs seeking to integrate traditional wisdom with modern business strategies. By combining historical perspectives with

Keywords: Traditional Guilds (Shrenis); Family Businesses; Ancient Trade Wisdom; Business Ethics; Succession Planning

1. Historical Foundations of Shrenis in Indian Economic History

Ancient Indian commerce was characterized by sophisticated vocational guilds known as Shrenis. These entities exercised autonomy in framing commercial regulations, establishing craft quality standards, and guaranteeing business contracts.

2. Structural Parallels with Modern Multi-Generational Family Enterprises

Contemporary family businesses display deep structural congruence with ancient Shrenis. Key shared attributes include value-based governance, intergenerational mentorship, and long-term stewardship orientations.

3. Succession Planning, Ethics & Knowledge Stewardship

The preservation of tacit technical and commercial knowledge through familial apprenticeships provided historical guilds with enduring resilience. Modern family ventures face identical challenges in generational succession.

4. Conclusion & Implications for Modern Venture Strategy

Integrating ancestral ethical benchmarks with modern corporate governance mechanisms provides a resilient blueprint for sustainable, community-oriented entrepreneurship.

References & Scholarly Citations

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